



Spirited bunch: Athletes and staff of the Army Para Sports Node stand outside their gymnasium in Pune, a unit built by injured soldiers and now producing Paralympic and Asian Games medallists.

Yet soldiers possess a defining strength. "Their mindset is rock solid. After injury, they are deeply depressed. It takes time to accept reality. But once they do, they think they have nothing more to lose. They give everything. They never give up," Murtaza says.

Beyond medals, there are tangible rewards. Army para athletes are eligible for promotions and cash incentives like any other Army sportsperson. Last year, Hokato Sema also became the first from the Node to receive the Arjuna Award. "Ten years ago, I would never have imagined this. Now, every athlete here believes it is possible," he says.

Winning medals, changing lives

Material success, however, is only part of the story. "When I think of where I was when I joined and where I am now, my entire life has changed. I feel I have served the country again. Seeing my posters up at the barracks makes me proud," says Rana. Ajay echoes the sentiment. After winning silver in the 400m T64 at Hangzhou, perceptions in his village shifted. "Earlier, people called it my

misfortune. Now they say I've brought honour. But the happiest moment was seeing my son try to pin my medals on his sweater. I used to do that with my father's medals. That day, I felt truly proud," he says.

Perhaps what soldiers value most is restored self-respect. "After injury, the biggest fears are whether you will walk again and whether people will pity you. Time at the Node answers both," says Solairaj.

For Sema, the transformation is visible in something simple. "I used to hide my stump out of shame. Now I wear shorts everywhere. If people stare, I let them. I tell others with disabilities: never be shy. Turn it into strength, rise to the top, and make your country proud," he says.

Having experienced this change, many athletes now recruit others. Ajay convinced 200m runner Rajvir Singh to join. Solairaj mentors Kalai, a 23-year-old from his former unit.

None, though, has inspired as many as Someswararao. "When my leg was removed, I thought my life was over. I remember I was going to go to the bathroom with a razor in my hand with the intention of ending

my life before I was stopped. Sports gave me purpose," he says. "When I came to ALC, I saw that my patient number was 43425. That means there must be close to 50,000 soldiers with some form of disability and at least a few thousand who are in their 20s and 30s."

Now, Someswararao is preparing for the next chapter. Having last represented India at Hangzhou, he is studying for a diploma in sports coaching at the National Institute of Sports. If he qualifies in 2026, he will be the first soldier from the Node to do so. "I may not have won a major medal for India, but I want to produce champions. The Node changed my life. I want to do the same for others," he says.

Back at the Node, the focus remains immediate. The 2026 Commonwealth and Asian Para Games loom. For Solairaj, there is also the elusive eight-metre jump. "I've jumped 7.32m in trials. Eight metres is a big leap. It won't be easy. But nothing is impossible. Everything comes down to hard work and training. That's what I'm preparing for," he says.